

« Unless the ICC can think of redistributing the funds that can help out the poorer nations, we will see Test cricket declining apart from the top nations »

DAVID GOWER

Shayan Acharya

shayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

Former England captain David Gower isn't against Bazball — but he believes Test cricket's future hinges on something bigger than England's approach. One of England's most elegant batters, Gower scored 8,231 runs in 117 Tests at an average of 44.25, with 18 centuries to his name — and he's now calling for the ICC to urgently rethink how it supports its 'relatively poor' member nations if the longest format is to survive.

Speaking to *Sportstar* on the final day of the third Test at Lord's, Gower weighed in on the 'inevitably flawed' World Test Championship, praised Shubman Gill's early captaincy, and argued that for England, the challenge isn't to abandon Bazball — but to know when to rein it in.

With aggressive batting and quick results becoming the norm in Tests, how do you view this shift — and do you worry about its impact on batting craft?

The idea of batting positively isn't new. Back in 1985, during the Ashes here, we scored at over four an over in five of six Tests — which, for that time, was rapid. The Australians of the '90s did it too: they'd score quickly to give (Glenn) McGrath and (Shane) Warne time to bowl teams out — and still fit in a round of golf. So, the concept has always existed. What England have done under (Ben) Stokes and (Brendon) McCullum is take it to new heights. The (Jonny) Bairstows, the (Zak) Crawleys, and others who love their shots have recorded scoring rates that are the highest in the last three to four years. And on its day, it's thrilling to watch.

There's huge entertainment value in it, but also a slightly desperate need to prove that Test cricket can still be entertaining. We're talking on the fifth morning of this Test, and the buzz is absolutely electric. It was the same last night. This entire series has had moments that have reminded everyone what five-day cricket can offer.

For those lucky enough to be at the ground, it's a real event — something you feel. That isn't something you get with formats where you pop in for a couple of hours and leave with a result. I still believe Test cricket is the highest form of the game by some distance.

When Virat Kohli says it is, that's great PR — because 1.4 billion people hear him. But we need more people speaking up for it. What we — my generation especially — always wanted from England was a blend of flair and grit. In the Lord's Ashes Test two years ago, they collapsed in an hour of madness; only Stokes stuck it out. Since then, a few others have started to ride out the tough periods, then push on again with clear skies and fair winds. That's progress. Over the past four years, there were moments when a different approach for an hour or two might have changed the result. And now, in this series, you can see they've begun to learn from those.

The pace of the Lord's Test has been different. Batting hasn't been